Plan a circle: “Little Women”

Louisa May Alcott (1868–69) · public-domain novel (Part 1 or whole) · grades 7–9 · ~2–3 weeks. Rights: Public domain.

Kit section 5 (group agreement & calendar) filled in for one text — a finished plan students see before writing their own. ***Tinted italic*** = sample answers.

Preview note: Preview period gender expectations, religious references, and illness/death (Beth); plan support.

Text, group, and target

Text / author / edition	***“Little Women” — Louisa May Alcott (1868–69). Public-domain novel (part 1 or whole).***
Group / period / dates	***Jo’s group · Period __ · Meetings ___ & ___***
Grade / TEKS target (p. 3)	Grade 8 · §110.24 — 7(A): theme through characters/events; 6(C,D): support inferences, summary; 1(D): student-led discussion.
Learning intention	We are learning to explain how the March sisters’ choices reveal a theme about ambition, family, and sacrifice.
Success criteria	I bring one open question, cite two details with chapter/page, respond to a peer, and name how my thinking changed.

Reading map & calendar

Chunk	Read through	Meeting date · leader
1	***Ch. 1–11: the sisters, “playing pilgrims,” Christmas, and meeting Laurie.***	***Wk 1 · Leader: Jo***
2	***Ch. 12–23: Beth’s scarlet fever, Meg’s romance, and Father’s return.***	***Wk 2 · Leader: Meg***

Members & first-meeting jobs (p. 7 roles)

Member	First job	Rotates to (next meeting)
Jo	***Questioner***	***Summarizer***
Meg	***Summarizer***	***Clarifier***
Beth	***Clarifier***	***Evidence tracker***
Amy	***Predictor***	***Questioner***

Text-specific discussion questions (open — more than one answer)

- **Predict:** Four sisters vow to bear their “burdens” — which sister’s ambition will cost or reward her most?
- **Question:** Why might Alcott frame the sisters’ growth as a “pilgrim’s progress”?
- **Clarify:** What does Jo mean by wanting to “do something splendid”?
- **Summarize:** Trace one sister’s main change in Part 1, without opinion.
- **Interpret the theme:** How do the sisters’ choices reveal a theme about ambition versus duty? Use two details.

> **Optional Jigsaw lenses (p. 4):** ***Character*** (Jo and her sisters) · ***Theme*** (ambition vs. duty) · ***Structure*** (the Pilgrim’s Progress frame) · ***Setting*** (the Civil War home front) · ***Language*** (the narrator’s moral asides).

Sample 3–2–1 notes: Beth, character (jo) lens

Name: Beth · Home group: Jo's group · Period __ · Meetings ___ & ___ · Section: "Little Women," Chunk 1 · Expert lens: Character (Jo)

> **What a finished prep looks like.** Kit section 6 / Organizer A completed for one reader, so students can compare their notes to a strong model.

Questions ***Which matters more to Jo — ambition or family?*** ***Is sacrifice rewarded in Part 1?***	**3 · Important ideas** ***1. Jo wants independence and to become a writer.*** ***2. She sacrifices for family — selling her hair to fund Marmee's trip.*** ***3. Beth's illness draws the sisters closer together.***
Vocabulary ***genteel = respectably refined.*** ***penitent = sorry for wrongdoing.***	**2 · Supporting details** ***1. Jo cuts and sells her hair (Part 1). → Shows sacrifice over vanity.*** ***2. The sisters give their Christmas breakfast to the Hummels (opening). → Duty over comfort.***

1 · Summary in my own words

Four sisters grow up in wartime poverty, each balancing personal ambition with love and duty to family.

Bring to the circle

My interpretation: ***Growing up means balancing one's own dreams with care for others.***
Synthesis (two lenses): ***Jo's choices (character) carry the theme: her ambition matters, but her sacrifices define her. Text points: the hair (Chunk 1) and the Hummel breakfast (Chunk 1).***
After discussion: ***My thinking became clearer once the group compared evidence.***

TEKS evidence: 6(C,D) supported inference; 7(A) theme through characters/events; 1(D) response to a peer.